

Ṣaḍripu: The Six Cardinal Enemies

In Hindu *dhārmika* thought, the term **Ṣaḍripu** (ṣaṭ = six, ripu = enemy) refers to six inherent tendencies that bind the *jīva* (individual soul) to *saṃsāra* (the cycle of birth and death). The word रिपु (**ripu**) is directly related to the Sanskrit root रिप् (**rip**), which is associated with the idea of "stain," "impurity," and by extension, "deceitful" or "treacherous". Figuratively, it means 'enemy'. The term 'षड्रिपु' (*Ṣaḍripu*) literally means 'six enemies'. It is also called 'अरिषड्वर्ग' (**Ariṣaḍvarga**).

These are:

1. Kāma (काम) – Lust / Desire

- Represents uncontrolled sensual or material craving.
- Rooted in selfish gratification, often leading to attachment and delusion.
- In the Bhagavad Gītā (3.37), kāma is described as a gateway to hell when unchecked.

The story of Indra and Ahalyā (Gautama)

The story of Gautama, Ahalyā, and Indra is a poignant episode from Hindu mythology, rich in moral and symbolic undertones. Ahalyā, created by Brahmā as the most beautiful woman, was given in marriage to Gautama ṛṣi, a sage of great spiritual stature. While Gautama was away performing his morning rituals, Indra, the king of the *devās*, overcome by lust, disguised himself as Gautama and approached Ahalyā. She too was attracted to him and knowingly consented. Upon discovering the transgression, Gautama cursed Indra to lose his manhood and to bear a thousand eyes; and condemned Ahalyā to a stone-like existence. She remained in that state until she is redeemed by the touch or presence of Śrī Rāma. When Rāma, accompanied by Viśvāmitra, enters the hermitage during his journey, Ahalyā is liberated from her curse, symbolizing the triumph of *dharma* and divine grace. This tale, found in the *Vālmiki Rāmāyaṇa* and echoed in various *Purāṇas*, explores themes of desire, deception, punishment, and redemption.



The story Śiva and Kāmadeva



Once Kāmadeva, the god of love, arrived at Kailāsa with his wife Rati, and as spring blossomed around the mountain, he aimed his sugarcane bow, strung with a line of buzzing bees, and released a floral arrow toward Śiva. The arrow struck, and Śiva's meditation broke. But instead of awakening love, Śiva's third eye, which is the symbol of transcendent awareness and destruction,

flared open in fury. In an instant, Kāmadeva was reduced to ashes. Rati, devastated, pleaded for mercy. Moved by her grief and devotion, Śiva granted that Kāmadeva would live on as *anāṅga*, the bodiless one, whose presence would still stir love and desire, but without a physical form.

These two stories tell us of what happens when we fall to lust and when we triumph over it. Now let's understand its ill effects:

Social and Psychological Effects of Lust

1. Adultery and Fornication

- Breach of marital fidelity leads to emotional trauma, loss of trust, and social stigma.
- Violates the principle of *pativrata dharma* and disrupts family harmony (*gṛhastha āśrama* ideals).
- Often results in long-term psychological distress for all parties involved.

2. Ruined Marriages and Relationships

- Uncontrolled lust fosters dissatisfaction, comparison, and infidelity.
- Undermines emotional intimacy and mutual respect.
- Leads to breakdown of familial structures, affecting children and dependents.

3. Sexual Perversion

- When desire becomes compulsive or distorted, it may manifest in harmful or exploitative behaviours.
- Indicative of unresolved psychological conflict or trauma.
- Often alienates individuals from healthy social bonds and spiritual grounding.

4. Prostitution and Pornography

- Commercialization of lust commodifies the human body, reducing relationships to transactions.
- Can perpetuate cycles of exploitation, sex-trafficking, and addiction.
- Desensitizes emotional responsiveness and distorts perceptions of intimacy.

5. Primitive Jealousy

- Lust often breeds possessiveness and envy, especially when coupled with insecurity.
- Leads to irrational behaviour, conflict, and emotional volatility.
- Contradicts the dharmic ideal of *śānti* (peace) and *śamatva* (equanimity).

6. Unsteady Focus

- Excessive indulgence in sensual thoughts disrupts mental clarity (*citta-vṛtti*).
- Hampers academic, professional, and spiritual pursuits.
- In yogic psychology, it is seen as a major obstacle to *dhyāna* (meditative absorption).

How to overcome lust?

Overcoming **kāma**, or lust, begins with cultivating mastery over the body and mind. Through **yoga** and **meditation**, one channels inner energy toward clarity and restraint, while regular **physical exercise** stabilizes hormonal impulses and enhances discipline. Seeking a **stable and meaningful relationship** rooted in emotional depth rather than fleeting desire helps redirect passion into commitment and mutual growth. Avoiding **pornography** is essential, as it distorts perception, fuels compulsive behavior, and disconnects one from authentic intimacy. It is vital to recognize that you are **more than your genitals**—your identity is not confined to physical urges but is expansive, conscious, and capable of transcendence. Finally, setting a **higher purpose or goal**—be it spiritual, creative, or intellectual—elevates the mind beyond base cravings and aligns desire with dharma. In essence, lust is not suppressed but transformed, from a consuming fire into a guiding light.

2. Krodha (क्रोध) – Anger

- Arises from unfulfilled desires or perceived injustice.
- Destroys discernment (viveka) and leads to impulsive actions.
- *Gītā* (2.63) warns that *krodha* leads to delusion and loss of memory, ultimately ruining intellect.

The Story of King Parīkṣit and Sage Śamīka

King Parīkṣit, the grandson of Arjuna and a righteous ruler, was once wandering in the forest after a long hunt, fatigued and parched with thirst. In search of water and rest, he came upon the hermitage of **Śamīka ṛṣi**, a sage deeply absorbed in **samādhi** (समाधि). Parīkṣit respectfully approached, but the sage, immersed in inner silence, did not respond. Misinterpreting this as arrogance or neglect, Parīkṣit got angry and in a moment of lapse placed a **dead snake** around the sage's neck as a mock garland and left the hermitage.



Later, **Śṛṅgi** (शृङ्गि), the young son of Śamīka and a fiery brāhmaṇa, heard of the insult. Without fully grasping the context or his father's detachment, he pronounced a curse: *"May King Parīkṣit die in seven days, bitten by Takṣaka (तक्षक), the serpent king."* When Śamīka emerged from his trance and learned of the curse, he was deeply troubled. He recognized Parīkṣit's remorse and felt the punishment was disproportionate. He sent messengers to warn the king. Just imagine what a mere moment of anger can do to you!

Key Hormonal Changes During Anger

When a person experiences anger, the body undergoes a rapid and complex hormonal shift that prepares it for a perceived threat—commonly known as the **fight-or-flight response**. This reaction is orchestrated by the brain's **amygdala**, which detects danger and signals the **hypothalamus** to activate the **sympathetic nervous system**. Here's what happens hormonally:

- **Cortisol** (the stress hormone): Levels spike sharply during anger. Elevated cortisol increases blood pressure, suppresses digestion, and heightens alertness. Chronic anger can lead to persistently high cortisol, contributing to anxiety, insomnia, and weakened immunity.

- **Adrenaline (epinephrine)** and **Noradrenaline (norepinephrine)**: These hormones surge from the adrenal glands, increasing heart rate, dilating pupils, and redirecting blood flow to muscles. They create the physical sensations of anger—racing heart, flushed face, and tense muscles.
- **Testosterone**: Often associated with aggression, testosterone levels may rise during anger, especially in competitive or confrontational situations. This can amplify assertive or hostile behavior.
- **Serotonin**: This neurotransmitter typically helps regulate mood and impulse control. Low serotonin levels are linked to increased irritability and poor emotional regulation, making it harder to manage anger constructively.

Brain Regions Involved

- **Amygdala**: Triggers the emotional response before rational thought can intervene.
- **Prefrontal Cortex**: Responsible for judgment and impulse control; often overridden during intense anger unless trained through mindfulness or emotional regulation.

The Neurological Imbalance

- **Adrenaline and Cortisol**: The adrenal glands, located on top of the kidneys, release these hormones in response to perceived threats or stressors, including anger. When someone experiences anger, the body releases stress hormones like adrenaline (epinephrine) and cortisol, which prepare the body for a "**fight-or-flight**" response. These hormones cause physical changes like increased heart rate, blood pressure, and muscle tension, readying the body for action.
- Chronic activation of stress hormones, as might occur with frequent or prolonged anger, can negatively impact health, increasing the risk of cardiovascular problems, weakened immunity, and other health issues.

How to 'manage' anger?

In the **Western psychological framework**, anger is typically addressed through **management techniques**—a pragmatic approach that emphasizes behavioural regulation. This includes practices like deep breathing, cognitive reframing, journaling, and attending anger management therapy. The goal is to **control the outward expression** of anger, making it socially acceptable and less disruptive. Anger is seen as a natural emotion that must be acknowledged and channelled constructively, often without delving deeply into its metaphysical roots.

In contrast, the **Indic tradition**—rooted in dharmic philosophies—views anger (*krodha*) as one of the **Ṣaḍripu**, the six inner enemies that obstruct spiritual

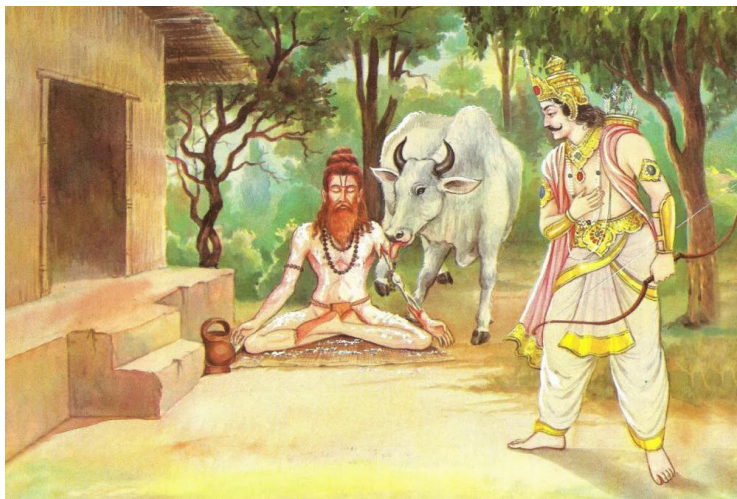
evolution. Here, the emphasis is not merely on managing symptoms but on **understanding the intrinsic causes** of anger: ego (*ahaṅkāra*), attachment (*moha*), and desire (*kāma*). Through introspection, meditation (*dhyāna*), and ethical living (*dharma*), one seeks to **eliminate the root of anger**, not just suppress its expression. Texts like the *Bhagavad Gītā* (2.62–63) warn that anger arises from unfulfilled desire and leads to delusion and loss of wisdom. Thus, its eradication is essential for liberation (*mokṣa*).

In essence, while the **Western model seeks to manage anger**, the **Indic path seeks to transcend it**—transforming reactive emotion into reflective awareness.

3. Lobha (लोभ) – Greed

- The insatiable desire for more—wealth, power, status.
- Prevents contentment (*santoṣa*) and fuels envy and exploitation.
- Greed is seen as a root cause of *adharma* (unrighteousness) in many Purāṇic narratives.

The story of Viśvāmitra and Vasiṣṭha



Viśvāmitra, once a powerful *rājārṣi* (राजर्षि), ruled with might and ambition. During a royal expedition, he arrived at the serene āśrama of **Vasiṣṭha**, a revered *brahmarṣi* (ब्रह्मर्षि), whose hermitage radiated peace, *tapas*, and divine presence. Vasiṣṭha welcomed the king with humility and offered him and his vast army a lavish

feast—not with worldly resources, but through the miraculous powers of **Kāmadhenu**, the celestial cow gifted by Brahmā. Kāmadhenu could manifest any object or sustenance desired, fulfilling wishes instantly. Viśvāmitra, astonished by the cow's powers, coveted her for his kingdom. He demanded Kāmadhenu from Vasiṣṭha, arguing that such a treasure belonged with kings, not ascetics. Vasiṣṭha calmly refused, explaining that Kāmadhenu was meant for dharmic service, not royal ambition. Enraged, Viśvāmitra tried to seize the cow by force. But Kāmadhenu, loyal to Vasiṣṭha, produced divine warriors from her body—races like the Pahlavas, Śakas, Yavanas, and others—who defeated Viśvāmitra's army effortlessly.

Humiliated and defeated, Viśvāmitra realized that **spiritual power (brahma-tejas)** far surpassed **military might (kṣatra-tejas)**. He renounced his throne and embarked on a rigorous path of tapas, determined to attain the status of a brahmarṣi himself.

The Characteristics of Greed

- Greed is insatiable.
- Enough is never enough.
- Greed blinds you to the ones who are needy.
- It's like adding ghee to the fire. The more you add, the more the fire burns.

How to check on greed?

- Compassion and empathy.
- Put yourself in other's shoe.
- Greed is not determined by the amount of wealth you have, but by the intent you hold. You may be rich and never greedy and you may also be poor and ever-greedy.
- When enough is never enough, it's best to think enough.

4. Moha (मोह) – Delusion / Attachment

- Emotional entanglement with transient worldly objects or relationships.
- Clouds judgment and leads to false identification with the body and ego.
- Moha is the veil of Māyā that obscures the soul's true nature.

The story of Dhṛtarāṣṭra and Gāndhārī



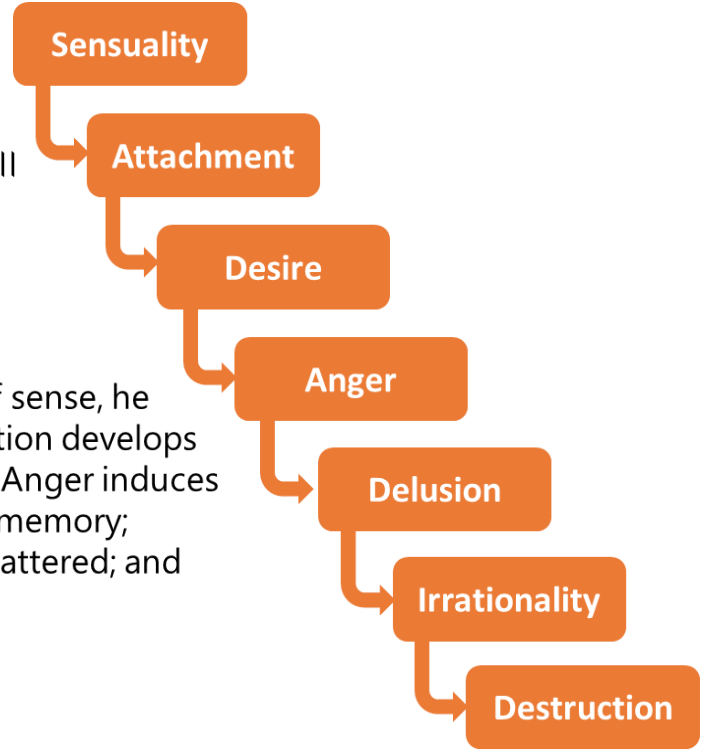
The **putramoha** (पुत्रमोह or excessive attachment to one's children) of **Dhṛtarāṣṭra** and **Gāndhārī** is a central emotional thread in the *Mahābhārata*. Dhṛtarāṣṭra, blind by birth and insecure in power, placed his hopes and identity in his eldest son, **Duryodhana**, despite knowing his adharmic tendencies. Gāndhārī, though virtuous and wise, remained bound by maternal loyalty, unable to restrain her hundred sons from their destructive path. Both parents, blinded not just by fate but by affection, ignored the counsel of sages and elders, allowing Duryodhana's envy and ambition to fester. Their *putramoha* ultimately led to the Kurukṣetra war, resulting in the annihilation of their lineage and lifelong grief.

What causes delusion according to the *Gītā*?

ध्यायतो विषयान्पुंसः सङ्गस्तेषूपजायते।
सङ्गात् संजायते कामः कामात्क्रोधोऽभिजायते॥
क्रोधाद्भवति संमोहः संमोहात्स्मृतिविभ्रमः।
स्मृतिभ्रंशाद् बुद्धिनाशो बुद्धिनाशात्प्रणश्यति॥

(*Bhagavad Gītā* 2.62-63)

When a man dwells on the objects of sense, he creates an attraction for them; attraction develops into desire, and desire breeds anger. Anger induces delusion and delusion brings loss of memory; through loss of memory, reason is shattered; and loss of reason leads to destruction.



Explanation: Verses 2.62–63 of the *Bhagavad Gītā* offer a profound psychological insight into the descent from contemplation to spiritual ruin. Śrī Kṛṣṇa explains that when a person **dwells on sense objects** (*dhyāyato viṣayān puṁsaḥ*), they develop **attachment** (*saṅga*). From attachment arises **desire** (*kāma*), and when desire is obstructed, it turns into **anger** (*krodha*). Anger clouds judgment (*sammoha*), leading to **loss of memory** (*smṛti-bhramśa*), which in turn destroys **intellect** (*buddhi-nāśa*). With intellect lost, the person is **ruined** (*praṇaśyati*). This sequence is not merely poetic, it maps the subtle workings of the mind. In Indic psychology, *kāma* and *krodha* are among the *Ṣaḍripu*, the six inner enemies. The verses caution that even a moment of indulgent thought can spiral into delusion. The loss of *smṛti* implies forgetting one's dharma, and the collapse of *buddhi* means losing the capacity for discernment (*viveka*). Thus, spiritual downfall begins not with action, but with unguarded thought.

5. Mada (मद) – Pride / Egoism

- Inflated sense of self-worth, superiority, or arrogance.
- Blocks humility (vinaya) and receptivity to higher wisdom.
- Often linked with ahaṅkāra (ego) in Vedānta, which must be transcended for liberation.

The story of Hiraṇyakaśipu and Rāvaṇa (two examples of insolence)



Hiraṇyakaśipu, a daitya king, sought immortality through a boon from Brahmā, making him nearly invincible. He declared himself supreme and persecuted devotees of Viṣṇu, including his own son, Prahlāda, who remained unwavering in his bhakti. Enraged by Prahlāda's devotion, Hiraṇyakaśipu challenged him, asking if Viṣṇu resided in a pillar. When Prahlāda affirmed, the pillar burst open and Narasiṃha—Viṣṇu's man-lion incarnation—emerged. Narasiṃha killed Hiraṇyakaśipu at twilight, on a threshold,

with his claws, bypassing the boon's conditions. This story, from the *Bhāgavata Purāṇa*, symbolizes the triumph of devotion over tyranny and the divine protection granted to the righteous.

Rāvaṇa's downfall was rooted in his unchecked **ahaṅkāra** (अहंकार), or ego. Though a master of the Vedas, a devotee of Śiva, and ruler of the prosperous kingdom of Laṅkā, Rāvaṇa allowed pride in his power and intellect to cloud his judgment. His belief in invincibility, bolstered by boons from Brahmā, led him to violate dharma by abducting Sītā, the wife of Rāma, despite knowing the moral and cosmic consequences. He dismissed wise counsel from his brother Vibhīṣaṇa and underestimated Rāma's divinity. His refusal to surrender Sītā, even when faced with defeat, exemplified how ego blinds one to truth. In the end, Rāvaṇa's destruction by Rāma was not merely a physical conquest but a symbolic annihilation of arrogance. His story stands as a timeless warning: ego, when left unchecked, transforms greatness into ruin.



Signs of Insolence

- **Disrespect toward elders, teachers, or spiritual authorities**
Ignoring or mocking those who uphold dharma is a classic sign of avajāṇā.

- **Excessive pride in one's knowledge, status, or power**
Known as **māna** or **garva**, this leads to a false sense of superiority and entitlement.
- **Refusal to accept correction or guidance**
A person steeped in insolence resists advice, even when offered with compassion and wisdom.
- **Sarcasm, mockery, or belittling speech**
Indic traditions emphasize **vāg-yoga**—discipline of speech. Insolent speech violates this principle.
- **Breaking social or ethical norms with arrogance**
Not out of ignorance, but with deliberate defiance and self-glorification.
- **Lack of gratitude or acknowledgment**
Ingratitude toward benefactors or mentors reflects spiritual immaturity and egoism

How to be free from insolence spiritually?

“सर्वं खल्विदं ब्रह्म” : Knowing that you are made of the same spirit as others are.

“आत्मवत्सर्वभूतेषु” : Treat all beings as you treat yourself.

“परहितार्थं इदं शरीरम्” : Know that this life is to help others.

6. Mātsarya (मात्सर्य) – Envy / Jealousy

- Resentment towards others' success or happiness.
- Breeds hostility and undermines compassion and unity.
- Considered a corrosive emotion that poisons relationships and spiritual growth.

The story of Vinatā and Kadrū

Vinatā (विनता) and Kadrū (कद्रू), daughters of Prajāpati Dakṣa, were both married to the sage Kaśyapa. When granted boons, Kadrū asked for a thousand serpent sons, while Vinatā wished for two radiant and powerful sons. Kadrū's eggs hatched first, producing her nāga children, but Vinatā's remained unhatched. Impatient and envious, Vinatā broke one prematurely, resulting in Aruṇa (अरुण), born half-formed. Angered by her haste, Aruṇa cursed



Vinatā to become Kadrū's slave. Later, the sisters saw the celestial horse **Uccaiṣravā** (उच्चैःश्रवा), born from the ocean's churning. They wagered on its tail color—Vinatā claimed it was white, Kadrū insisted it was black. To win, Kadrū deceitfully instructed her serpent sons to cling to the tail and darken it. When Vinatā lost, she became enslaved to Kadrū, fulfilling Aruṇa's curse. This tale, found in the *Ādi Parva* of the *Mahābhārata*, reveals how **jealousy and deceit** lead to suffering. Vinatā's impatience and Kadrū's manipulation both stemmed from *moha* (delusion) and *mātsarya* (envy), resulting in bondage and humiliation. Liberation came only through the birth of **Garuḍa** (गरुड), Vinatā's second son, who later freed his mother and became the eternal enemy of serpents, a cosmic echo of their rivalry.

Thank you.